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Haggai and Zechariah

Two prophets who got a discouraged people building again, one with plain rebukes and one with visions of hope.

By 520 BC the temple's foundation had lain untouched for about sixteen years while the exiles built their own homes. Then God raised up two prophets. Haggai spoke short, direct messages: "Consider your ways." Within weeks the work began again. Zechariah, from a priestly family, called the people to return to the Lord and spoke of a King "lowly, and riding upon an ass." The temple was finished in 516/515 BC.

At a glance

Names	Haggai, probably "festive"; Zechariah, "the Lord remembers"
Family	Zechariah, "son of Berechiah, the son of Iddo" (Zech 1:1)
When	Haggai: 520 BC. Zechariah: 520 to at least 518 BC
Task	To stir the people to finish the temple and renew their faith
Key people	Zerubbabel the governor; Joshua the high priest; Darius I
Main passages	Ezra 5:1–2; 6:14; Haggai 1–2; Zechariah 1–14
New Testament	Hebrews 12:26; Zechariah in the Gospels' passion accounts

"And the elders of the Jews builded, and they prospered through the prophesying of Haggai the prophet and Zechariah the son of Iddo."

Ezra 6:14, KJV

The life of Haggai and Zechariah

Dates approximate (BC), counted by the reign of Darius I (from 522 BC).

- c. 520 BC
6th month

● The first message

Haggai says the people live in panelled houses while God's house lies in ruins. Within the month, the work begins again. *Haggai 1:1-15; Ezra 5:1-2*
- c. 520 BC
7th month

● The promise of glory

To those who think the new temple is "as nothing," Haggai says God will shake the nations and fill this house with greater glory. *Haggai 2:1-9*
- c. 520 BC
8th month

● Zechariah's first word

Zechariah calls the people not to be like their fathers: "Turn ye unto me ... and I will turn unto you." *Zechariah 1:1-6*
- c. 520 BC
9th month

● Haggai's last messages

Haggai warns that unclean hearts make offerings unclean, promises blessing, and calls Zerubbabel God's signet. *Haggai 2:10-23*
- c. 519 BC
11th month

● The night visions

Zechariah sees visions by night, usually counted as eight, including a man measuring Jerusalem and a golden lampstand. *Zechariah 1:7-6:8*
- c. 518-515 BC
Fasting and finishing

● Mercy, then a finished temple

Zechariah answers a question about fasting: God wants justice, mercy and truth. The temple is finished in Darius's sixth year. *Zechariah 7:1-8:23; Ezra 6:14-15*

Group notes

Key activities

Zechariah 9–14 has no dates and a different style from chapters 1–8. Many scholars think these chapters come from a later prophet. Others hold that Zechariah wrote the whole book, perhaps later in his life.

- 1 Haggai confronted misplaced priorities.** "Is it time for you ... to dwell in your cieled houses, and this house lie waste?" *Haggai 1:3–11*
- 2 Haggai encouraged the builders.** He brought one short message from God: "I am with you, saith the LORD." *Haggai 1:13; 2:4–5*
- 3 Haggai promised greater glory.** God would fill the plain new house with glory and "give peace" in it. *Haggai 2:6–9*
- 4 Haggai taught about holiness.** Using questions for the priests, he showed that holiness does not rub off, but uncleanness does. *Haggai 2:10–19*
- 5 Zechariah called for repentance.** He urged the people to turn back to God instead of repeating their fathers' mistakes. *Zechariah 1:1–6*
- 6 Zechariah saw God's care in visions.** The Lord would be "a wall of fire" around Jerusalem, rebuke Satan and clothe Joshua in clean garments. *Zechariah 2:5; 3:1–5*
- 7 Zechariah crowned Joshua as a sign.** He set crowns on the high priest's head and spoke of "the man whose name is The BRANCH," who would build the temple. *Zechariah 6:9–15*
- 8 Zechariah put mercy above ritual.** He told the people to "shew mercy and compassions every man to his brother." *Zechariah 7:4–10*
- 9 Zechariah announced a humble King.** "Thy King cometh unto thee ... lowly, and riding upon an ass." *Zechariah 9:9*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name them.

Old Testament

Ezra 5:1–2; 6:14	Their preaching helps the builders finish the temple
Nehemiah 12:4, 16	Iddo's priestly family among those who returned
Echo: Jeremiah 23:5	Zechariah's BRANCH echoes Jeremiah's righteous Branch

New Testament

Hebrews 12:26–27	Quotes Haggai 2:6 on God shaking heaven and earth
Matthew 21:4–5; 26:31	Jesus fulfils Zechariah 9:9 and quotes 13:7
Matthew 27:9–10	Thirty pieces of silver recall Zechariah 11:12–13
John 19:37; Revelation 1:7	"Him whom they pierced," from Zechariah 12:10
Matthew 23:35	"Zacharias son of Barachias": this prophet? Readers differ

For discussion

- Observe:* What were the people doing while God's house lay in ruins (Haggai 1:3–9)?
- Understand:* Why might God send a blunt prophet and a visionary one together?
- Apply:* "Consider your ways." Where is your time or money going that needs rethinking?
- Apply:* Fasting without mercy misses the point. What act of mercy can you do this week?